

Meta's Orion outshines Apple's Vision

You don't have to try on the Meta Orion AR smart glasses to know they're better than Apple Vision Pro where it matters the most – the fact that they don't look like a sci-fi heads-up-display (HUD) from a Hollywood set!

For the average consumer, who doesn't geek out on the most minutest of tech specs in the newest 'AR glasses' on the market and considers a pair of spectacles for what they ultimately are – a utilitarian fashion statement like no other, it seems the Meta Orion is just what the doctor ordered.

Revealed last month at Meta Connect 2024, the Meta Orion prototype AR glasses boasts several interesting features that set it apart as a cutting-edge AR device. Orion's a sleeker, cooler, and functionally a more realistic take on an AR wearable than what we saw with the Apple Vision Pro. It's still early days for this prototype, of course, but from all the videos and pictures released by the company, the Meta Orion AR smart glasses appear to be lightweight and designed for all-day wear, making them suitable for both indoor and outdoor use. They also integrate Meta AI, which provides contextual assistance, recognising what you're looking at and offering real-time help, such as making video calls or managing schedules without needing a phone. This is such a cool feature, if it works as advertised – like everything from an always-on Google Lens that's constantly scanning your field-of-view for things it can analyse and give you more information on to operating your phone virtually by just your voice or vision.

Right now, the Meta Orion smart glasses boast a respectable field of view of 70 degrees through their lenses, which is quite good. While the lenses may appear slightly darker, they still allow users to maintain eye contact and perceive facial expressions, ensuring a natural interaction – which is a huge win compared to something like the Apple Vision Pro.

While the Orion prototypes might have left some wishing for a more slender frame, especially when compared to the sleeker Ray-Ban Meta smart glasses, there's no doubt that Meta



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will refine the design before the final product hits the market later next year.

Orion's transparent lenses ensure you can still see the eyes and expressions of those around you, making social interactions more natural. And the best part? There are no pesky cables to tangle with on the Meta Orion AR smart glasses, something you can't say about the Apple Vision Pro right now. The Meta Orion smart glasses offload some of its AR processing to a small 100 gm ball that connects wirelessly to the glasses to project apps and 3D graphics to the viewer – which is a far cry from the 350-gm wired brick attached to the Apple Vision Pro.

Now coming back to my opening remark, on why I think the Meta Orion appeals to more consumers than Apple Vision Pro ever would in its current form. And yes, technically this is a comparison between smart glasses and HUD headset like the Apple Vision Pro – ideally a fairer comparison would be between Meta Quest 3 and Apple Vision Pro. I don't think the average mass consumer cares about a fair fight, they care about what they'll choose between the two form factors, which I believe to be smart glasses.

With the Orion AR smart glasses prototype, not only has Meta manifested in the present what the Apple Vision Pro might trickle down to ultimately sometime in the not-so-distant-future, Meta has said the Orion glasses might be as much as one-third of the price of the Apple Vision Pro. That price point itself, coupled with the fact that its subtle and fashionable aesthetic appeal to a wider audience, will ensure the Meta Orion will sell more than Apple Vision Pro or any other AR/VR headset. It begs the question why didn't Apple make AR smart glasses to begin with, compatible with its vision of spatial computing?

It's ironic that Apple, which takes great pride in making fashionable consumer electronics that end up being style statements for the larger industry, seems to have been one-upped by Meta here. In the latest between Apple CEO Tim Cook and Meta CEO Mark Zuckerberg's very public feud, Zuckerberg sure will be smiling for now. **d**